



“What’s happening on WhatsApp in India is inspiring customers across the world. Meta is committed to helping businesses in India build valuable journeys on WhatsApp”

MATT IDEMA

VP, BUSINESS MESSAGING, META



“We built the business platform, WhatsApp, and it can enable any type of business. You can buy tickets for Bengaluru metro and scan the e-ticket to board the train; and even book cabs”

RAVI GARG

DIRECTOR, BUSINESS MESSAGING-INDIA, META

52 |



“India is a long way from China, but it still has 200 million+ online shoppers, 65 million+ MSMEs and \$100 billion in GMV today—the opportunity for conversational commerce is huge”

AKHILESH TUTEJA

PARTNER & HEAD OF TECHNOLOGY, MEDIA AND TELECOMMUNICATION, KPMG IN INDIA



“A third of customers conversing with a generative AI-powered chatbot end up buying a product. The bot... keeps them engaged till the decision to buy is made”

PRASHANT GARG

TECHNOLOGY CONSULTING PARTNER, EY INDIA

sage a business at least once a week, considerably higher than the global average of 66 per cent.

Ravi Garg says that business messaging provides customers with a personalised experience, something that shopping online generally lacks. EY’s Prasahant Garg adds that if an AI-powered chatbot is at work, it can provide customers with a personalised experience that even a brick-and-mortar store is unable to, since the bot has to engage with a single customer while a shop assistant has to attend to many. He adds that AI-powered chatbots can be added to existing websites or apps to drive customer engagement. This is done by using turnkey solutions powered by conversational AI that uses data, machine learning, and natural language processing to imitate human interactions, recognise speech and text inputs, and translate their meanings across languages. For instance, software giant IBM has such a solution called IBM Watson Advertising Conversations, which helps facilitate personalised AI conversations with consumers virtually anywhere online.

While the space is set to grow rapidly in India, it is not without its challenges. Tuteja of KPMG in India says that customising and training a conversational AI product in a country with around 22 official languages along with the required accuracy, is possibly the biggest challenge. The next challenge is enabling security and privacy for the users of the conversational AI product in a manner compliant with the local laws, he says, adding that ensuring human bias and examples of unethical behaviour from the training data do not pass into the AI is another big challenge.

Meta’s Ravi Garg says that for WhatsApp, user privacy remains at its core, despite it being open for business. “Messaging is the best way for people and businesses to connect, and India has led that transformation on WhatsApp. The scale, use-cases, and new buying experiences from the region are things we are really excited to see. What’s happening on WhatsApp in India is inspiring our customers all over the world. With business messaging as a top priority for Meta, we’re committed to helping businesses of all sizes in India to build valuable journeys on WhatsApp and keep innovating in this space,” says Matt Idema, VP of Business Messaging at Meta.

As for my Kolkata-based relative, he is happy with the convenience afforded by technology as it offers him more time for other pursuits. Wonder what other chatbots he will start conversing with next. **BT**

@abhik_sen